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Boaz

The generous landowner of Bethlehem who became Ruth's kinsman-redeemer.

Boaz was "a mighty man of wealth" in Bethlehem and a relative of Naomi's late husband, Elimelech. When the Moabite widow Ruth came to glean in his field, he protected her, fed her and quietly left extra grain for her. When she came to him at night on the threshing floor, he treated her with honor and promised to act. At the city gate he settled the matter before the elders, bought Elimelech's land and married Ruth. Their son Obed became King David's grandfather.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Boaz</i> , often explained as "in him is strength"
Family	Son of Salmon; husband of Ruth; father of Obed (Ruth 4:21)
Described as	"A mighty man of wealth, of the family of Elimelech" (Ruth 2:1)
When	"When the judges ruled" (Ruth 1:1); no firm date
Key places	Bethlehem, his barley field, the threshing floor, the city gate
Key people	Ruth, Naomi, the nearer kinsman, the elders
Descendants	Great-grandfather of David (Ruth 4:21–22)
New Testament	Matthew 1:5; Luke 3:32 (as "Booz")

"The LORD recompense thy work, and a full reward be given thee of the LORD God of Israel, under whose wings thou art come to trust."

Ruth 2:12, KJV

The life of Boaz

Ruth gives no calendar date. Matthew 1:5 names Boaz's mother as Rachab, usually taken to be Rahab of Jericho. If so, Boaz lived early in the judges' period, and the family list from Boaz to David may skip generations.

Barley harvest	● Meets Ruth Boaz comes from Bethlehem and greets his reapers, "The LORD be with you." He asks about the young woman gleanng and learns she is the Moabitess who came back with Naomi. <i>Ruth 2:1-7</i>
That day	● Shows her kindness He tells Ruth to stay in his field and orders the young men not to touch her. He invites her to eat with the reapers, and he tells them to let fall handfuls of grain on purpose for her. <i>Ruth 2:8-16</i>
At the threshing floor	● Makes a promise Waking at midnight, he finds Ruth at his feet. He blesses her kindness and promises to act, but notes that a nearer kinsman comes first. He sends her home with six measures of barley. <i>Ruth 3:7-15</i>
At the gate	● Redeems the land Before ten elders he offers the nearer kinsman Elimelech's land. When the man learns he must also marry Ruth, he declines and draws off his shoe. Boaz buys the land and takes Ruth as his wife. <i>Ruth 4:1-10</i>
Afterward	● Father of Obed The elders bless him, praying that his house will be like the house of Pharez. Ruth bears a son, Obed, who becomes the father of Jesse and the grandfather of David. <i>Ruth 4:11-17</i>

Group notes

Key activities

A "kinsman" (Hebrew *go'el*, often called a kinsman-redeemer) was a close relative who could buy back family land or rescue a relative in need (Leviticus 25:25). Ruth 4 also draws on the custom of raising up a dead man's name through his widow (Deuteronomy 25:5–10), though Boaz was not a brother-in-law.

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- 1 **Blessed his workers.** He greeted his reapers with "The LORD be with you," and they blessed him in return. *Ruth 2:4*
 - 2 **Noticed the outsider.** He asked about Ruth and learned of her loyalty to Naomi. *Ruth 2:5–11*
 - 3 **Protected her.** He told her to stay with his young women and ordered the young men not to touch her. *Ruth 2:8–9*
 - 4 **Prayed for her.** He asked the LORD to reward her, "under whose wings thou art come to trust." *Ruth 2:12*
 - 5 **Gave more than required.** He let her glean among the sheaves and had handfuls dropped on purpose for her. *Ruth 2:15–16*
 - 6 **Acted with honor at night.** He guarded Ruth's good name and sent her home before anyone could recognize her. *Ruth 3:10–14*
 - 7 **Did things in order.** He gave the nearer kinsman the first right before acting himself. *Ruth 3:12–13; 4:1–4*
 - 8 **Redeemed publicly.** Before elders and people he bought the land and took Ruth, "to raise up the name of the dead." *Ruth 4:9–10*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Boaz.

Old Testament

Ruth 2–4	This is the main account.
Ruth 4:18–22	and 1 Chronicles 2:11–12. Boaz is listed between Salmon (Salma) and Obed.
1 Kings 7:21	and 2 Chronicles 3:17. One of the bronze pillars at Solomon's temple was named Boaz. Scripture does not say whether it was named after him.
Echoes	The laws of gleaning (Leviticus 19:9–10) and of redeeming land (Leviticus 25:25) come to life in his field and at his gate.

New Testament

Matthew 1:5	"Salmon begat Booz of Rachab; and Booz begat Obed of Ruth."
Luke 3:32	Booz appears in Luke's genealogy of Jesus.
Echoes	Many Christians see Boaz as a picture of Christ the Redeemer, "who gave himself for us, that he might redeem us from all iniquity" (Titus 2:14).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Boaz tell his young men to do for Ruth (Ruth 2:8–9, 15–16)?
2. *Understand:* Boaz could have married Ruth quietly. Why do you think he gave the nearer kinsman the first chance?
3. *Apply:* Boaz went beyond what the law required. Where could you be generous beyond what is expected this week?
4. *Apply:* Boaz greeted his workers with a blessing. How do you speak to the people who work for you or with you?